

Creative 6.1 6600

The lone ranger in the 6.1 category, the speaker has a very decent set of features, though we do wish it had a few more controls on the remote, akin to the Logitech Z5300, which lets you control everything you can think of!

The setup was fairly straightforward (you start feeling that way after installing and un-installing 25 odd speaker systems!). The bass was trademark creative-the thumping of bomb explosions will have you running for cover. In fact, the bass is so powerful that it made CDs and other assorted items lying on our desks vibrate! The overall audio experience of these speakers was extremely impressive, though not quite exceptional.

The movie surround experience and sound clarity was really good, and when watching a clip where

glass shatters, we could make out where every little piece of shattered glass fell.

In the music department, these speakers gave us really good results so long as there were only a few instruments and a little electronic mixing, but once we started running the Enigma songs, we found these speakers to be slightly low in clarity and individual sound reproduction. Also, the speakers had trouble reproducing the lower frequencies. The low frequency reproduction was better at lower volumes, but then you want your music loud, don't you?

We don't mean to imply that these speakers are bad, but we are saying that they could have been better. Then again, for just Rs 7,500, they are a steal for those who want a budgeted 6.1 audio experience.

ideology: make it look sleek, futuristic and sexy as hell!

On opening the Artis X10 box, we were greeted with some really sturdy and top-quality speakers. We were really impressed with the quality metal stands and the woofer. The design, however, seemed to be inspired by Bose.

An interesting entry was the Jazz mini home theatre. This is a tiny system. It isn't fair to compare this system with the biggies we had, but even by itself, the sound quality was pretty poor, and got extremely tinny even at mid-volume levels. We didn't have any great expectations from the extremely small bass unit, and as it turned out, it produced less bass than the satellites did!

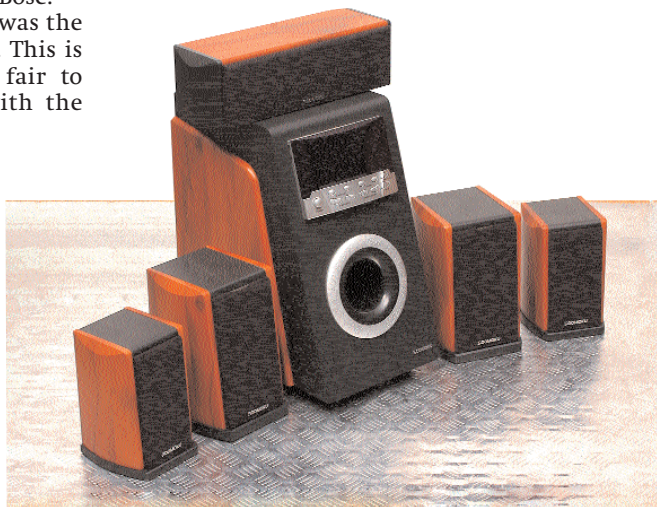
Another really jazzy looking system was the Soomoku 5.1. The satellites and the woofer were made of shining brown wood, but the woofer had a rather cheap-looking pseudo-metallic finish. The woofer had a nice LCD for various operations, but made the entire system look a little too loud.

We also had a set of Hyundai speakers. One look at these and we knew that Hyundai kept compactness only to the Santro (Xing or otherwise). Put together, these huge speakers

could probably measure up to a Hyundai Santro!

Put Your Money Where The Sound Is!

The test process used for the 5.1 systems was exactly the same as for the previous systems. As



Soomoku 5.1 (5.1)

usual, we started with our bass tests, and plugged in the Creative 5.1 system first.

This was the single most devastating thing we could have done for the other speakers, because there was simply no match for the depth and punch of the Creative 5.1 MegaWorks.

The second in this category was the Philips A 3.610, followed closely by the Artis X10. The

main reason that the Artis X10 lost out was that at high volumes—beyond 90 per cent—there was extreme distortion in the bass.

The Creative Inspire 5200 came in a commendable fourth, considering it costs just a third of the abovementioned speakers.

These results were, however, not entirely replicated in our individual frequency tests. The Artis X10 edged out everybody else in the 30 Hz test, with the Philips A3.610 a close second, followed by the Creative MegaWorks.

In the 50 Hz test, Philips was head and shoulders above the rest, with the MegaWorks coming in second, followed by the X10. It kept rotating back and forth between these speakers for the remaining frequencies, but the fight was mostly between the Artis X10 and the Creative Mega-works 5.1 THX.

We then popped in our DTS sampler disk and heard Eric Clapton and Sheila Nicholas crooning their hearts out.

The Altec Lansing BS3151R thrashed almost all the other speakers comfortably, and beat everyone to the top slot. The sound from this speaker set was extremely impressive considering the size and price.

The Philips 3.610 tied for the second slot with the Creative MegaWorks 5.1.

Both provided excellent blend of bass depth and vocals. At no time did we feel that the bass was overpowering the satellite sound or that the bass was too timid.

In the case of the MegaWorks, it seemed that the bass had just no limits! It went on without too much trouble at higher and higher volumes, and the Philips 3.610 pretty much kept up all the way, until both the speakers' satellites began to crackle slightly.

The third place was jointly held by the Creative PC works LX520 and the Soomoku 5.1.

We found that at higher volumes, the Soomoku's bass tended to be slightly weak, whereas in the Creative PC Works, the bass gave up when the volume was turned all the way up. The loser here, and by a fairly large margin, was the Artis X10. It was comprehensively beaten by all the above speakers, as well as by the Creative Inspire 5200.